

DOCTOR WHO? DOCTOR TUNA!

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The British science fiction television show “Doctor Who” has been entertaining audiences for over half a century. Academics have studied this program from numerous perspectives and disciplines, including Gender Studies (Jowett 2014; Orthia & Morgain 2016), Race Studies (Orthia, 2013; Gupta, 2013), Religious Studies (Balstrup 2014; Seton, 2013; Aston & Walliss 2013), Mass Media and Communication (Walden 2016; Hills 2014; Butler 2014), Law & Philosophy perspective (Ball, 1988; Symes 2014; Decker 2013; Stoker 2008) Politics and Policy perspective (McKee 2004; Dixit 2012; Edwards VL 2014; Layton 1994), Psychology (MacRury & Rustin 2014; Stannard 1988; Purkis, Lester & Field 2011), Education (Davis 2014; Harrett & Benjamin 2009), Physics (Jaffe, 2013), Business (Broadbent 2007), Literature and Linguistics (Marlow, 2009; Jones 2015; Levy 2009; Burdge, Burke & Larsen 2010), and Music (Butler, 2013; Mosaic 2009; Leitch 2013), amongst others.

I considered Alfred “Tuna” Snider a mentor for most of my life. An intellectually gifted teacher who had many interests, his enjoyment of *Doctor Who* was always on the top, or near the top, of his many passions. On Tuna’s passing I could not stop myself from reflecting on how much Tuna seemed to have in common with the Doctor, the lead character of his beloved series. This character was played by different actors as each incarnation of the Doctor passed, regenerating into a new Doctor as part of an ever-shifting plotline. Although each Doctor was different, they all had several things in common with each other. The Doctor’s most successful powers were eerily similar

to Tuna's powers and strategies at mentoring others. This essay will reflect on three of the big similarities between Tuna and the Doctors: control of time, interacting with companions, and the boundless desire to do good. Because *Dr. Who*, the show, was so important to Tuna Snider, any analysis of his life would be lacking an incomplete without some discussion of its role in his life.

On the show, *Doctor Who* is a humanoid alien who is a Time Lord. Time Lords have great powers partly because of their non-linear perspectives on time and their command of time travel technology. For those not familiar with the show, I find it difficult to concisely describe. It is a drama whose main character is called the Doctor; the Doctor has "regenerated" twelve times since the show first began in 1963. This regeneration results in a new actor entering the series to play the Doctor. Each Doctor is different yet they all have some similarities in common; they try to do good, they are smart and knowledgeable, they are intensely curious, and they all have an ego. Additionally, each doctor has the ability to move about space and time in an old English police call box. Although Tuna often related stories to me of how others had suspected him of not being from this planet because of his unique and sometimes idiosyncratic ideas, his time bending powers came from his superior time management skills and ability to work in a sustained, disciplined way on numerous projects at one time. Good time managers are very organized in the way they launch projects, select manageable due dates, and continually review long term goals. Tuna was an early adapter of the personal computer, smart phone and other technologies that helped him organize his time better. He used these technologies continually to help him complete multiple tasks simultaneously. A brief look at Tuna's extensive travel and work schedule

(which he sometimes shared publicly online) shows meticulous planning and personal discipline that most would be incapable of achieving. Despite achieving so much with his time saving and organizing skills, Tuna did not spend a lot of time explaining to other people the secrets of his time management powers. He would rather quote The Doctor in the season seven Christmas special when he stated "Do what I do. Hold tight and pretend it's a plan." The reality was both The Doctor and Tuna Snider demonstrated that good planning was essential for success. The Doctors had the advantage of their time traveling device, the TARDIS, and Tuna had the advantage of his exceptional time management skills and tech devices like his trusty laptop.

As one who learned many things from Tuna, it seems his preferred way to mentor was reliant on the person being mentored to pay close attention to what Tuna was actually doing to get the great results he did. Thus, teaching by example was one of Tuna's preferred ways to demonstrate what he thought worked. By watching Tuna closely, I got to see firsthand how important time management skills can be used when he organized a plethora of events inside and outside of debate. These included running the tab room of several college and high school national tournaments, helping organize a series of gigantic reggae concerts, and orchestrating more international debate training workshops than any other individual person has ever done.

The Doctor had a great many companions that he met over the years in numerous ways. Often times the companions would travel with him all over the place and they always seemed to be having adventures together. There is no doubt in mind that many of the people Tuna mentored could be described as his

“companions” in the Doctor Who sense. Just like The Doctor, Tuna had a love of adventure and loved traveling. When possible he preferred traveling with “companions.” These companions included colleagues, students, and various people he met while journeying through the world. There was no such thing as a “cookie cutter” companion relationship for The Doctor or Tuna. Each of his companion relationships were as unique as the journeys they traveled on together and the adventures they had. It would be easier to describe all of The Doctor’s companions than it would be to be able to describe all of Tuna’s companions. Of course, it is easy to understand how a 900-year-old alien with a TARDIS that can transport the Doctor and his companions all over the universe and back and forth through time would have no problem finding companions to travel with him. Tuna, on the other hand, collected companions differently but just as effectively. By relying the power of his personal charisma and strong charm, Tuna could attract a wide variety of individuals that wanted to spend time with him as a companion and indulge him in his adventurous side.

To understand Tuna’s power to attract companions one must endeavor to comprehend Tuna as truly remarkable story teller. The Doctor in Season 5, Episode 13 states, “We’re all stories, in the end. Just make it a good one, eh?” I felt nearly all of Tuna’s stories were good ones and whenever he would begin telling one people would gather around if possible and focus their attention. More than once, I have dined with Tuna and strangers from tables nearby would be wholly engaged in listening to the story Tuna was telling with no attempt to hide their enjoyment in being close enough to hear the tale he was sharing. Of course, Tuna as an academic had studied the formal structure and nuance

of good storytelling. His natural ability to add his good humor to any story made him an irresistible tale teller. Like with all great storytellers his best stories got better over time because he was not afraid to embellish if it helped him get his point across or accomplish his mission. I was lucky enough to go on a number of journeys with Tuna as his companion. I enjoyed the trips, but I loved the stories.

The Doctor and Tuna had many characteristics that they shared. The last one this essay will consider is their boundless desire to do good. In Season 6, Episode 6 The Doctor states, “I am and will always be an optimist. The hoper of far-flung hopes and the dreamer of improbable dreams.” This great optimism allowed both The Doctor and Tuna to try things others would never attempt. The Doctor was always saving the universe, the planet, the country, or some hopelessly trapped human. Fighting off monsters of all sorts, The Doctor prevailed often with the aid of his strong will and his inability to give up. I saw Tuna fight off many metaphorical monsters in his attempt to save things he held near and dear to his heart. There was not a place on the globe that Tuna would not travel to in order to spread the magic of debate. The number of letters of recommendation he wrote each year was tremendous large. The number of lives he touched for the better even larger. How was Tuna able to motivate himself to do so much good? I believe he like to focus on the positive whenever he could even though he could have easily let negativity get the best of him. The Doctor in Season 5, Episode 10 says: “The way I see it, every life is a pile of good things and bad things. The good things don’t always soften the bad things, but vice versa, the bad things don’t always spoil the good things and make them unimportant.” Tuna, like The Doctor, more often saw the pile of good things and did what he could to make that pile bigger.

In short, Alfred “Tuna” Snider shared some of the most important characteristics of the fictional character called The Doctor on the long running British science fiction TV program. His superb time management and organizational skills helped him manipulate time and space; his relationship with his companions aided by his terrific storytelling ability helped him and them on a plethora of adventures and journeys in an incalculable number of places; his infinite desire to do good was bolstered by an endless optimism that he could make a difference. Today he inspires all that he knew to try harder, do more, and be better. Tuna Snider on reflection was so much better than The Doctor who he loved. Tuna Snider really lived and his memory will continue to inspire those who knew him and those that have benefited and will in the future benefit from his vision of spreading healthy debate everywhere.

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